The ICAO Flight-Plan Form: Read It Field by Field

A flight plan tells ATS who is flying, the proposed route and level, the timing and the information needed if assistance is required. AAI requires the ICAO model flight plan for the information supplied about an intended flight or part of a flight.

Sources: AAI eAIP ENR 1.10 §1.2; ICAO Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §§1–2.

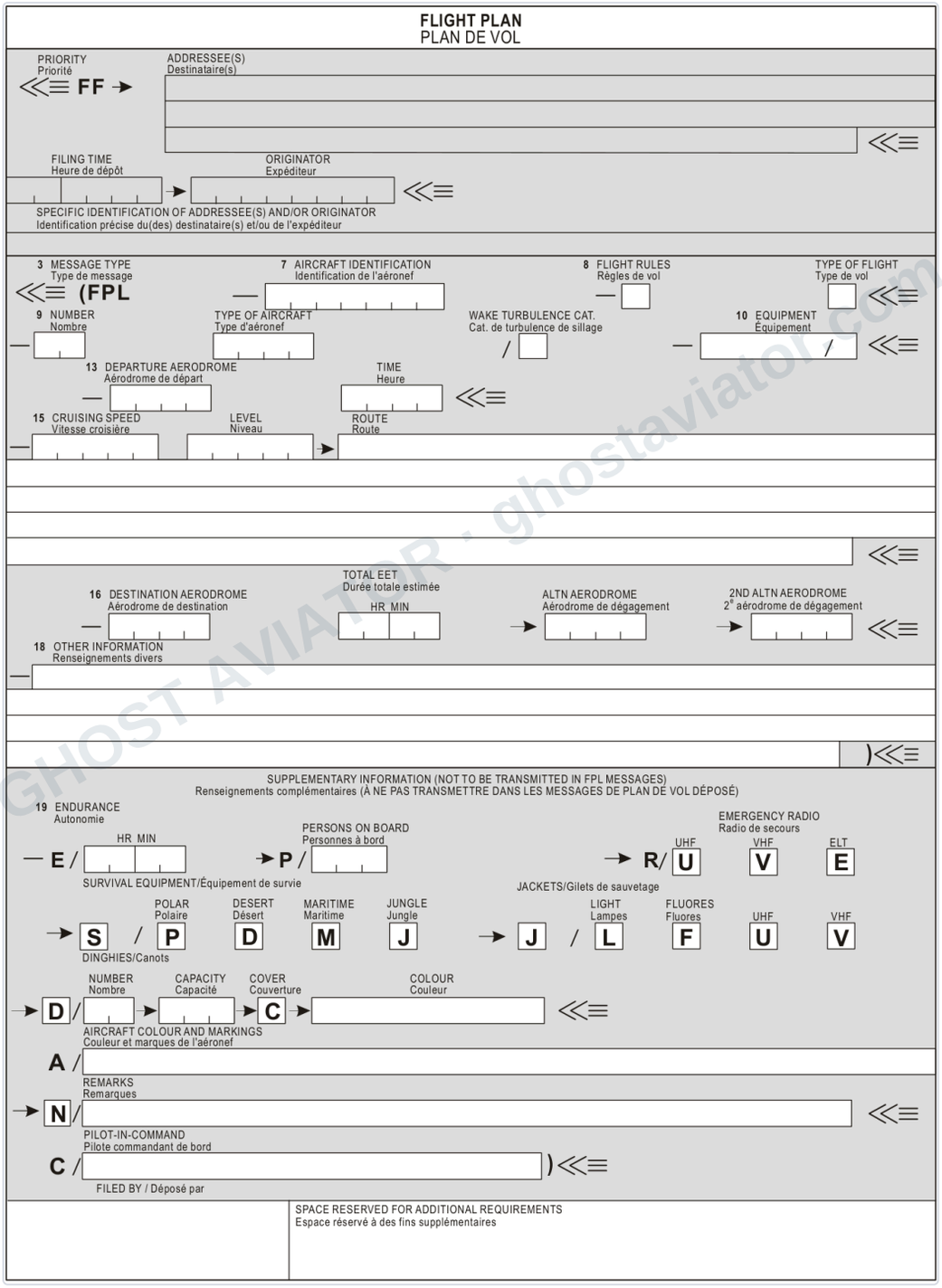


Figure 3.1 *ICAO model flight-plan form — layout reproduced from Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §1, page A2-2. The numbered fields are explained below.*

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Flight-plan terms — regulation and meaning

Flight plan: “Specified information, relative to an intended flight or portion of a flight of an aircraft.” In simple English: the specified information about the flight or the part of the flight concerned.

Filed flight plan (FPL or eFPL): “The latest flight plan as submitted by the pilot, an operator or a designated representative, for use by ATS units.” This is the latest submitted plan.

Current flight plan (CPL): “The flight plan, that reflects changes to the filed flight plan, if any, by subsequent ATC clearances.” This is the submitted plan with changes made through later ATC clearances.

Estimated off-block time: “The estimated time at which the aircraft will commence movement associated with departure.” It concerns departure movement, rather than take-off.

Source: DGCA CAR Section 9, Series C, Part I, Definitions, printed pages 7–8.

Before filling the form

Start at the first available space in each field. Use four figures for clock time in UTC. Use four figures, hours followed by minutes, for elapsed time. The item numbers have gaps because they correspond to ATS message field numbers.

Three different times: `0930` in Item 13 means an off-block clock time of 09:30 UTC for a pre-departure flight plan. `0130` in Item 16 means 1 hour 30 minutes of estimated elapsed time. `E/0430` in Item 19 means fuel endurance of 4 hours 30 minutes. These entries answer different questions.

Source: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.1 and §2.2, Items 13, 16 and 19.

The message header and Item 3

The shaded header contains message priority, addressees, filing time and originator. Addressees are the ATS message addresses that must receive the plan. The originator is the unit or organisation sending the message. Filing time is a message-handling time; it is not the aircraft’s departure time. The header is completed by ATS/COM services unless message origination has been delegated. Item 3 identifies the message as `FPL`, a filed flight plan.

Sources: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §§1, 2.1 and 2.5; AAI eAIP ENR 1.10 §4 for Indian addressing responsibilities.

Item 7 — Aircraft identification

Enter the aircraft identification, with a maximum of seven characters. This may be the registration, or the ICAO operating-agency designator followed by the flight identification, as applicable to the call sign being used. Keep the flight-plan identification consistent with the identification used by the aircraft’s surveillance equipment.

Sources: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 7; AAI eAIP ENR 1.6 §15.8.2.

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Item 8 — Flight rules and type of flight

Flight rules	Meaning	Type of flight	Meaning
I	IFR	S	Scheduled air service
V	VFR	N	Non-scheduled air transport
Y	IFR first; specify the change point in Item 15	G	General aviation
Z	VFR first; specify the change point in Item 15	M / X	Military / other than the listed categories

Enter type of flight when required by the appropriate ATS authority. For example, `IG` identifies IFR general aviation. This describes the proposed flight; it does not itself grant a clearance.

Source: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 8. X means other than the listed categories.

Item 9 — Number, aircraft type and wake category

Enter the number of aircraft when there is more than one. Use the ICAO aircraft type designator. If no designator exists, or a formation contains different aircraft types, enter `ZZZZ` and give the required types and numbers after `TYP/` in Item 18. Enter the applicable wake-turbulence category after the slash. Aircraft type and wake category describe different things; use the category assigned under the applicable current ATS provisions.

Source: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 9; aircraft type designators are specified in ICAO Doc 8643.

Item 10 — Equipment and capabilities

The part before the slash describes communication, navigation and approach equipment/capabilities. The part after the slash describes surveillance equipment/capabilities. The entry must represent what is serviceable and applicable to this flight. Having a box installed is not the same as holding an operational approval for every use of that box.

For Indian ADS-B flight planning, AAI specifies `B1` for dedicated 1090 MHz ADS-B OUT and `B2` for OUT and IN. AAI also specifies the applicable Mode S designator in the surveillance part. These are examples of surveillance entries, not a complete equipment string to copy into every flight plan.

Sources: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 10 for field structure; AAI eAIP ENR 1.6 §§15.2.2, 15.3.1 and 15.8.1 for Indian ADS-B approval and flight-planning requirements.

Item 13 — Departure aerodrome and time

Enter the departure aerodrome's four-letter ICAO location indicator, followed by the estimated off-block time for a plan filed before departure. Off-block time means the planned time the aircraft starts leaving its parking position; it is not take-off time. If the aerodrome has no assigned indicator, use `ZZZZ` and identify it after `DEP/` in Item 18.

For a flight plan received from an aircraft already in flight, use `AFIL`. The time then refers to the actual or estimated time over the first point to which the plan applies. Item 18 identifies the ATS unit from which supplementary flight-plan information can be obtained.

Source: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 13.

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Item 15 — Cruising speed, level and route

Begin with the first cruising speed and level, then enter the route. Cruising speed here is true airspeed or the prescribed Mach format, not IAS. Use `N` plus four figures for knots, `K` plus four for kilometres per hour, or `M` plus three for Mach. A flight level uses `F` plus three figures; an altitude in hundreds of feet uses `A` plus three. Metric formats apply where prescribed.

> `N0120A045` means 120 kt TAS and an altitude of 4,500 ft. `N0450F330` means 450 kt TAS and FL330. These are format examples, not route or level clearances.

Describe the route using the applicable ATS-route designators and significant points. Use `DCT` for direct portions where the instructions require it. Identify planned changes of speed, level or flight rules at the relevant point. For a speed or level change, give both the speed and level after the point and slash, even if only one changes. An IFR/VFR change point must agree with Item 8.

Source: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 15(a)–(c), including (c)(3) and (4).

Item 16 — Destination, total EET and alternates

Enter the destination's four-letter ICAO indicator followed by total estimated elapsed time in hours and minutes. Enter up to two destination alternate aerodromes in the spaces provided. Where an indicator has not been assigned, enter `ZZZZ` and identify the aerodrome in Item 18 using `DEST/` or `ALTN/`, as appropriate.

Total EET is a duration, not an arrival clock time and not fuel endurance. For a flight plan received in flight, it is measured from the first point to which that plan applies.

Total estimated elapsed time — where it ends: For IFR, the CAR measures from take-off to the designated navigation-reference point where the instrument approach is intended to begin; if no navigation aid is associated with the destination aerodrome, it ends over that aerodrome. For VFR, it measures from take-off to arrival over the destination aerodrome. It is a duration, and does not automatically mean time to touchdown.

Source: DGCA CAR Section 9, Series C, Part I, Definitions, "Total estimated elapsed time", printed page 12.

Source: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 16.

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Item 18 — Other information and cross-references

Use the prescribed indicators followed by a slash. This field supplies detail that cannot be expressed fully in the earlier boxes. For example, `REG/` identifies registration when different from Item 7; `TYP/` expands ZZZZ in Item 9; `DEP/`, `DEST/` and `ALTN/` expand the relevant aerodrome entries; `EET/` gives accumulated elapsed times to specified points or FIR boundaries. `RMK/` carries required or necessary plain-language remarks.

AAI requires accumulated elapsed times to FIR boundary points where applicable, together with the pilot-in-command's telephone/mobile number, in Item 18. Additional authority details apply to the non-scheduled operations specified in ENR 1.10. Match Item 18 to the earlier fields; do not leave a ZZZZ entry unexplained.

Sources: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 18; AAI eAIP ENR 1.10 §§2.2.3, 2.3.4 and 2.4.4. This explanation covers the field's function and common cross-references; it is not the full current indicator catalogue.

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Item 19 — Supplementary information

These details support assistance and search and rescue. They are not transmitted in the basic FPL message shown on the form. Complete them as required by the appropriate ATS authority. On the paper form, cross out equipment indicators that do not apply; a remaining indicator describes equipment available.

Entry	What to enter or indicate
E/ — Endurance	Fuel endurance in four figures, hours and minutes.
P/ — Persons on board	Total passengers and crew. TBN means “to be notified” when the total is not known at filing.
R/ — Emergency radio	U: 243.0 MHz; V: 121.5 MHz; E: ELT. Cross out unavailable equipment.
S/ — Survival equipment	P: polar; D: desert; M: maritime; J: jungle. Cross out categories not carried.
J/ — Life jackets	L: lights; F: fluorescein; U/V: radio capability. Cross out unavailable features; cross out all if no jackets.
D/ — Dinghies	Number, combined person capacity, cover and colour. Cross out D and C if no dinghies; cross out C if not covered.
A/ — Aircraft appearance	Colour and significant markings to help identify the aircraft.
N/ — Remarks	Other survival equipment or relevant survival remarks; cross out N if none.
C/ — Pilot	Name of the pilot-in-command.

Source: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §2.2, Item 19; Appendix 2 §3 for FPL-message transmission.

Filed by, acceptance and the remaining space

“Filed by” identifies the person, agency or unit submitting the plan. ATS acceptance is recorded in the manner prescribed by the appropriate authority. The final reserved space accommodates additional requirements. Filing, acceptance and an ATC clearance are separate steps.

Source: Doc 4444, Appendix 2 §§2.3–2.5; AAI eAIP ENR 1.10 §§2 and 4.

Indian filing and departure requirements

Except where necessary for operational or technical reasons, submit the flight plan to the appropriate ATS unit at least **180 minutes before estimated off-block time**. For RPA, the provision specifies at least 24 hours before estimated departure. These are Indian submission requirements, separate from the time formats on the form.

For a proposed departure delay of **15 minutes or more** after filing, the pilot-in-command or representative must notify ATC of the revised departure time. Amend the plan where applicable, or submit a new plan and cancel the old one.

At the engine-start or taxi request, pass total persons on board and report that security checks have been completed to the appropriate clearance-delivery, surface-movement or aerodrome-control unit. Where RNAV/RNP SIDs are in use, report non-RNAV status before pushback and start-up.

Source: AAI eAIP ENR 1.10 §§3.1–3.4.

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